

BROTHERS IN ARMS EARNED IN BLOOD

Every so often, one wishes that one could palm off a game review to someone else. I've always maintained that the WWII theme has been grossly overdone—from strategy to shooters to god-knows-what. *Brothers in Arms: Earned in Blood* (EiB) is a mix of both—you need strategy and tactics to finish your enemy, as well as some of that “blowing holes in people” thing that we all love so much.

‘F’ Words

In EiB, you follow the (real-life) experiences of Sgt Joe “Red” Hartsock, as he and his squad made their way around France, dodging “those blasted Krauts” and their Panzers. There is no real story, actually—you just live through all their missions, while Red describes them to a Colonel S.L.A. Marshal in a post D-Day interview.

You clearly aren't Rambo. If Red's slightly wimpy-looking character doesn't give that away, then the fact that frontal assaults often result in death will. You need to follow the four ‘F's to get rid of your enemy—Find, Fix, Flank, Finish! To fix your enemy, you need to lay bullets on them thick—this will suppress them, and you can see this in the handy suppression indicator over their heads. Suppressed enemies fight back less, and are less accurate when they do. And now comes the strategy part—you need to figure out a way to get around them and hit them from the side. The “Situational Awareness Mode,” which gives you an aerial view of your location, lets you survey the scene around you, check out points with good cover, and decide on your attack strategy. Switching between shooter and situational awareness is seamless and quite impressive.

Gather Round, Children

The game has ten chapters, each of which is humanly possible to clear. Cutscenes fill the gap with some good

voice-acting, but you can't skip them if you just want to get straight to the action.

Once done with the chapters, turn to the skirmish mode—especially the ‘Timed Assault’, which has you eliminating as many enemies as possible in a given amount of time. Or try your hand at the back-breakingly tough “Tour of Duty”—five missions to complete without dying. You can go through skirmish missions as a German, too!

“Dammit Red, Get DOWN!”

EiB is not just about you. You have a squad to lead, and they will play an important role in your victory. Commandeering a team sounds dicey in anything but a strategy game, but this is alarmingly easy in EiB—a right-click here, a [Shift] there; big plus points to Gearbox for this. You usually get one Assault squad, and every so often, a Fire squad. And sometimes, that Fire squad is a tank. There's probably a ‘propah’ protocol for what squad to use for what purpose, but since they're both good at facilitating general mayhem, it doesn't really matter. Your team is smart enough to protect itself well in sticky situations, so you don't need to baby-sit them all the time. They also warn you of danger when you start taking bullets; this gets a tad repetitive.

“Let's get those %(*@#\$\$%s!”

Battlefields are good and busy in this game. While you shouldn't expect incessant, gut-wrenching battle all the time, it's still fun enough. Your enemies don't just shoot at you from their positions; while you sit and figure out your attack plan, they keep coming closer and flanking you—to pressure you into doing something stupid like standing up and blasting away with your gun, only to be quickly dispensed with.



Through these fields of destruction...



Baptisms of fire